



Training ground: Indian hockey midfielder Hardik Singh during a training session at the Sports Authority of India's Southern Centre in Bengaluru, located within the Jnanabharathi campus. K. MURALI KUMAR

Harmanpreet for the first time. He was a junior India player then. I would just stare at him thinking this is what an international player looks like," he says.

Competitive streak

Though his own village boasted significant hockey pedigree, Hardik says he often looked beyond it for inspiration.

"There were many people from my village who had competed in the Olympics, but there had been a long gap since the last Olympian and Olympic medal. I think there is another kind of motivation I got from seeing players closer to my own age compete at that level," he says.

"A player like Harmanpreet was already in the Indian junior team at the time that I was in the hockey academy. When he would come back from tours, he'd sometimes play along with us academy players. Seeing him play, I'd think, this is how I have to play as well. Every day was a battle for me just to show what I was capable of. If I was marking someone in training, I'd push myself, saying I had to steal the ball from him. I had

to catch him if I wanted to be better than him," he says.

Hardik says this kind of competitiveness was essential. "That envy is what it takes to probably get to the team. I wanted really badly to share the field and dressing room with those senior players. And to do that, I had to be better than them," he says.

He pushed himself to the limit. "My first hostel in Jalandhar was just a 20-minute drive from my home. Despite that, I didn't come home on weekends. I would wake up at 4 a.m., just so that I could do some extra training before the actual day started. If my evening training began at 4.30, I'd come in at 3.30 and leave an hour later just so I could get an extra edge," he says.

This came naturally to him.

"Some people wonder if I was pushed into hockey because I have so many generations who are hockey players, but I have no regret over the path my life took. Most people spend a lot of time searching for what their life's goal is. I think I am very thankful that I knew from the beginning of my life that I wanted to be a hockey player. It's not that it wasn't my grandfather's dream. He always hoped that I would make it to the Indian team some day, but the choice was mine. No one was forcing me to do this. And to make it to the Indian team, I had to outwork everyone," he says.

Unlike some of his teammates, Hardik didn't have a rapid rise through the ranks.

"Although I made it to the Indian junior team, I didn't make that kind of immediate jump into the seniors that players like Harmanpreet did. He was already in the Indian Olympic team (in 2016) while still a junior. I had to wait for my opportunity. There was a time when I was seriously thinking I should try to play club hockey in the Netherlands in order to get myself ready for the senior level," he says.

His senior international debut eventually came at the 2018 Asian Champions Trophy. That tournament remains special for another reason too.

"I remember just after our training session, a message went out to the team WhatsApp group asking the players who had just been announced as part of the Indian squad to choose their jersey numbers. There were a few numbers that had already been chosen. Harmanpreet has 13, Manpreet has 7, and Mandeep had 11. I always wanted jersey number 8. I was hoping no one had claimed it and luckily I was able to get it," he says.

Special jersey

Jersey number 8 was special for Hardik because it had previously been worn by former Indian skipper Sardar Singh.

"I think the first hockey player I was really a fan of was Sardar *bhai*. Back when I was a kid, I'd send messages to his *Facebook* account and hope he responded to me. Then, in 2014, when I got the chance to be a ball boy in the Hockey India League, I got to see him in real life when he was playing for Delhi Waveriders. He was this muscular guy, walking while holding his hockey stick in one hand and using a phone with the other. There were two people who were following him everywhere. When he was at the airport, people would clear out a way for him. He would hang out with all the actors and celebrities. And then he had that name — Sardar (which means leader). What could I say but that he had an aura? I was like, wow!"